FAA could provide assistance on all these fronts. Cooperation in this area will create the right environment for commercial deals, he said, without going into specifics on what type of assistance is necessary. A frustrated Ambassador observed that FAA has a solid history of collaboration with the Civil Aviation Directorate General and promised to investigate how the USG might best lend assistance.

5. (C) In addition to FAA assistance, Yildirim hinted obliquely that Turkey's desire to send an astronaut into space – expressed in a letter from President Gul to President Obama – is also tied into its consideration of commercial deals, and that NASA assistance to help stand up Turkey's nascent space program would be viewed positively. Ambassador Jeffrey noted that scheduling a Turkish astronaut on an upcoming mission would be extremely difficult, but that other technical assistance from NASA in establishing Turkey's space program might be a possibility.

6. (C) Comment: Yildirim's conflation of USG-GOT interactions and what is ostensibly a commercial sale between private firms suggests an unwelcome, but unsurprising, degree of political influence in this transaction. His comments may also explain the confusing mention of offsets by Prime Minister Erdogan in his meeting with the President - if the GOT is truly evaluating the sale as a "U.S." offer rather a Boeing offer, then the desired "offsets" may have been from the USG rather than Boeing. While there should not be a link between this deal and FAA/NASA assistance in developing Turkey's aviation and aerospace agencies, such assistance in and of itself could be mutually beneficial and merits further study. We probably cannot put a Turkish astronaut in orbit, but there are programs we could undertake to strengthen Turkey's capacity in this area that would meet our own goals for improved aviation safety in the region. In any case, we must/must show some response to the Minister's vague requests if we want to maximize chances for the sale. End comment.